Frustrated with the way the government had handled the entire situation, in October 2013 Ratan stated before the apex court that the intercepted phone calls were, in fact, leaked to the media because of corporate rivalry. Salve, while concluding his final arguments, also submitted: 'If a corporate battle had not happened, someone would not have leaked the secretly intercepted conversations. It would have remained on government files like so many others.'

While he did not elaborate on the identity of the rivals in the corporate battle, he simply claimed that 'a corporate involved in telecom machinations is involved in the leaks'. Ratan also firmly stated: 'The assertion of the right of the media to broadcast these tapes has to be evaluated against the invasion of the right to privacy … for [it's] obvious that the right to freedom of expression cannot be a euphemism for waging surrogate corporate war.'

Ratan Vindicated

In India, the media has usually played a stellar role in protecting democracy as a watchdog of the society. As the fourth pillar, there are not many instances where its conduct has warranted criticism. But its coverage of the 2G scam would qualify as among the most prominent of its failures.

As *The Washington Post* put it, India has a 'fiercely competitive' press. In the eagerness to outdo each other in a high-profile case that had generated almost unprecedented public interest, the rights of the people whose names figured in the Radia tapes were given a go-by. Anybody who spoke with Radia, irrespective of what was spoken or exchanged, was by default assumed to be a co-conspirator in the 2G scam. The frenzied media competition did not go unnoticed. In 2010, the Supreme Court stepped in to exhort the media to conduct itself responsibly and not engage in '"distorted" reporting'.

As the drama of the Radia tapes played out in various fora, the most important question that several influential leaders including Ratan raised was whether the conversations between him and Radia could qualify as private conversations, which the public, therefore, had no right to know. They contended that where there is no criminality involved, the right to privacy should be supreme.